

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 864

By Briggs

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Wesley Hazen Rucker of Knoxville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the untimely passing of Wesley Hazen Rucker; and

WHEREAS, a beloved husband, father, and son, Wes Rucker was a prolific, highly regarded sports journalist who covered University of Tennessee athletics for more than two decades; and

WHEREAS, a Knoxville native, Mr. Rucker attended Knoxville Catholic High School and the University of Tennessee (UT), from which he earned a bachelor's degree in journalism, focusing on sports communication; he famously missed a final exam to interview the legendary Pat Head Summitt; and

WHEREAS, he first covered the Vols for the UT student newspaper, *The Daily Beacon*, in 2000; as a student, he also wrote for the *Farragut Press Enterprise*, *The (Maryville) Daily Times*, and the *Chattanooga Times Free Press*; and

WHEREAS, after his time as a student at UT, Wes Rucker covered Chattanooga athletics for the *Chattanooga Times Free Press* and then transitioned to the Vols beat in 2007; he went on to serve as a senior writer for 247Sports, a media partnership that also featured his articles in *Knox News*; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rucker turned his passion for journalism, sports, and history into a two-decade career covering Tennessee athletics across print, radio, digital, and television media, hosting numerous radio shows and podcasts focused on the Vols and college sports; in 2025, he took a job with WBIR-TV, where he continued covering his alma mater as a writer and host; and

WHEREAS, a talented, award-winning writer with an incredible ability to find unique angles and weave compelling stories, Wes Rucker was also a trusted media voter for several polls and awards in college football and men's basketball throughout his career, including the Heisman Trophy and the Associated Press Top 25; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rucker embodied integrity, insight, and a genuine love for his community; he shaped conversations, mentored younger journalists, and helped define how Tennessee fans understood their teams; and

WHEREAS, he always had plenty to say on topics as wide-ranging as the Chicago Cubs and Arsenal Football Club to Alaskan vacations and James Bond movies, and, as someone who became nationally known for his work, he had friends in sports media that reached far beyond Knoxville; and

WHEREAS, above all else, Wes Rucker was deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, he is survived by his wife, Lauren; their son, Hank; and a daughter expected later this spring; he is further survived by his parents, Marty and Dale Rucker; siblings, Molly (Chris) Woods and Grant (Maggie) Rucker; nephew, Casen Woods; mother-in-law, Rosemary Phillips; and numerous aunts, uncles, and cousins; and

WHEREAS, he was preceded in death by his grandmother, Jerry Carla Maranville Wade; and

WHEREAS, those closest to Wes Rucker knew a man of infinite knowledge and never-ending conversation; he treated everyone with the utmost respect and kindness and was always willing to help others; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rucker leaves behind a legacy that stretches across press boxes, newsrooms, and living rooms; he will be remembered as an insightful storyteller and a man of integrity who placed his family values at the heart of everything he did; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Wesley Hazen Rucker, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Rucker.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.